

S09 B HEARING HEALTH CONSERVATION | O (MAX : 1 PT)

Intent : Increase access to resources and structured programming for employees who are at risk of occupational hearing loss.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects or organizations to implement policies and programs that support hearing health conservation.

Issue: The World Health Organization reports that approximately 466 million people worldwide have disabling hearing loss, of which 34 million are children.¹ Estimates suggest that by the year 2050 over 900 million people will have disabling hearing loss.¹ Typical environments where hazardous sound levels can occur include occupational settings where loud equipment is present (e.g., industrial spaces, airports, fitness studios), as well as settings where occupants regularly engage with personal listening devices (PLDs) that exceed safe listening levels (e.g., call centers, distance learning, recreational devices). Presbycusis, also known as age-related hearing loss, comprises most hearing loss cases.^{2–4} Studies have shown that individuals with hearing loss over the age of 65 are at higher risk for developing cognitive disorders like dementia and Alzheimer's disease.^{2,5,6} In all forms, hearing loss can lead to exclusion from communication and may impact social and emotional health by leading to feelings of loneliness, isolation and frustration, particularly among older populations.⁷ The annual economic impact of hearing loss is an estimated US \$750 billion, which accounts for costs related to healthcare (excluding the cost of hearing devices), educational support and loss of productivity and well-being.⁸

Solutions: Hearing health conservation programs that raise awareness about the risks of hearing loss and encourage individuals to use personal protective devices (e.g., earplugs, earmuffs) may help prevent noise induced hearing loss.^{8,10} Organization-wide programs that focus on the reduction of occupational noise exposure, provide access to regular hearing health screenings for vulnerable occupants and provide relevant staff with necessary training for use of loud equipment have been found to help limit disabling hearing impairments, reduce fatigue and in some cases improve morale and work efficiency.⁹ Companies that deploy these programs have reported reductions in medical expenses and worker compensation costs.^{11–13}

PART 1 IMPLEMENT A HEARING HEALTH CONSERVATION PROGRAM (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

1: Hearing health conservation program

The project maintains a hearing health conservation program that meets the following requirements:

- a. Provides hearing protection that is selected, fitted and maintained for all occupants at no cost to the occupant.¹⁴
- b. Demonstrates compliance with OSHA Code of Federal Regulations Title 29 Chapter XVII Part 1910 Subpart G, European Council Directive 89/391/CEE or equivalent.¹⁵⁻¹⁷
- c. Audiogram tests are made available to employees working in loud zones, at no cost in a room that meets ANSI S3.1-2018 (or equivalent) requirements for background noise levels, using calibrated audiometers as per the schedule below:
 1. Annually for all employees.⁹
 2. Pre-employment or during onboarding for all new employees.⁹
 3. Prior to initial assignment in a hearing-hazardous zone as determined by the hearing conservation program supervisor (see below).⁹
 4. At the time of reassignment out of a hearing-hazardous work area or job, as determined by the hearing conservation program supervisor (see below).⁹
 5. At the conclusion of employment.⁹

2: Hearing health conservation supervisor

The project designates a qualified hearing health supervisor whose responsibilities include the following:

- a. Coordinates at least one hearing health training (e.g., workshop, seminar) per year that educates all employees on the following topics:
 1. Hearing loss and well-being.⁹
 2. Audiometric results and hearing threshold levels.⁹
 3. Noise exposure levels.⁹
 4. Correct use of hearing protection.⁹
- b. Manages the use and purchasing of hearing protection, audiometers and noise measuring equipment.⁹
- c. Schedules annual audiometric evaluations for employees.⁹
- d. Conducts an annual audit to determine that the hearing health conservation program adheres to OSHA, European Directive or equivalent regional regulations.^{9,15,17}
- e. Provides educational resources on hearing health to employees upon request.

Note : This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

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